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Alcibiades' Role in Symposium: Unveiling the Power of Socratic Love

Alcibiades' appearance at the end of Plato's *Symposium* serves as the climax of the dialogue, adding a new dimension to the theme of love. His speech enriches the discussion by presenting a personal and emotional perspective, reinforces Socrates' philosophical ideas about love vividly, but most importantly, it highlights the educational power of Socratic love.

Firstly, in contrast with other people's (Agathon and Pausanias and so on) abstract and idealized speeches about Eros, such as "He is soft and tender, and he dwells in the softest of places, in the souls and hearts of gods and men" (195a-c), Alcibiades' understanding of love is much more personal and complicated, mixed with admiration and frustration. He tried all he could to seduce Socrates, such as exercising and wrestling with him (217c), and even managed to sleep beside him, though it did not work at all: "…but absolutely nothing happened; it was just like sleeping with one's father or elder brother" (219d). His love for Socrates manifests in a way that is closer to what an ordinary person would experience: filled with varied and complex emotions, showing vulnerability in front of love. Moreover, Alcibiades shows his true love through his passion, persistence, and honesty, which highlight his character. We feel deeply connected with him; he is endearing, and his speech is filled with humor, such as when he uses the metaphor: "I've been stung, or bitten, in my heart or soul by a method of philosophical argument" (218b). We truly praise him for being such an honest person. This sheds light on the theme of finding love: our approach to Eros can be multifaceted. We do not need to be cryptic, shy, or "noble" to love, as others in the *Symposium* did. We can be like Alcibiades, showing our true selves and true feelings, which is also a manifestation of the power of love. Our pursuit of love is deeply rooted in human nature.

Secondly, Alcibiades' appearance indeed highlights Socrates' understanding of love. Referring to the concept of "the ladder of love," we know that Socrates values spiritual love

more. Although he acknowledges physical desire, its ultimate purpose is to transcend this love and reach the concept of love itself, the ideal love. Through Alcibiades' anecdotes, we see Socrates' extraordinary self-control and wisdom. This portrayal reinforces the idea of Socratic wisdom as transcending ordinary human desires (Blondell).

Moreover, his transaction from frustration to admiration for Socrates highlights the power of Socratic love. From Alcibiades' dialogue, we can see that although he feels extremely frustrated by Socrates' rejection of his love, he respects Socrates' character even more: "I was humiliated yet full of admiration for his restraint and strength of mind." (219e) While Alcibiades initially seeks a physical relationship, he ultimately gains a deeper understanding and respect for Socrates' philosophical ideals, which shows the educational aspect of Socratic love--where the lover guides the beloved towards higher understanding and self-improvement(Blondell). Alcibiades' experience illustrates how love can be a powerful force for personal growth and enlightenment(Blondell).

In conclusion, Alcibiades' appearance at the end of Plato's *Symposium* is essential and contributes significantly to the main theme of the dialogue. It helps us better understand Plato's attempt to convey his philosophical understanding of love through the character and voice of Socrates.

(543 words)

Works Cited

Blondell, Ruby. "Where is Socrates on the 'Ladder of Love'?" *Plato's Symposium: Issues in Interpretation and Reception*, edited by James Lesher, Debra Nails, and Frisbee Sheffield, Center for Hellenic Studies, 2007, classics.washington.edu/research/publications/where-socrates-ladder-love.

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